Kate Fletcher

Professor Quaraishi

ENGL 223–Fall Fiction Writing I

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Collected Works

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Final Reflective Letter

Dear Professor Quraishi,

At the beginning of the semester, I wrote to you saying I didn't know what kind of writer I wanted to be yet—that some days I felt pulled toward law and logic and systems, and other days toward fiction and the surreal and anything that lets reality break open a little. I said writing was the only place where the measurable and immeasurable parts of my life could sit next to each other without needing to be resolved. I meant that then, and I still mean it now—but after this class, I think I finally understand what it looks like to actually write from that place instead of just talking about it.

I didn't realize how honest I was being when I told you I didn't know if I could finish anything I wrote. I didn't realize how much that fear shaped the way I approached fiction, or how I held myself back without meaning to. This semester has been a lot, both academically and in my personal life, and sometimes it felt like every part of my world was shifting at once. Coming off of Shields' death, and the months of physical, emotional, and mental exhaustion that followed, I didn't feel like I had anything left to give creatively. Fiction has always been escapism for me — a controlled environment where someone else's imagination holds you, distracts you, protects you. I never believed I could write that way myself, because I didn't think I could turn my own feelings into something fictional without it collapsing into memoir or trauma dumping or something too raw to share.

But my workshop story, *The Hum,* ended up becoming the first piece where I feel like I actually tried. I didn't really set out to write about grief, or disappearance, or the feeling that the world keeps moving while your life gets stuck. But that's just what came out. *And, honestly?* I

think that I was only able to get there because the workshop space you created felt safe enough for me to try.

When I reread my first reflection letter now, I can see how much uncertainty was sitting underneath it—in the jokes, in the self-deprecation, in the way I described my studies as a combination of measurable science and immeasurable emotion. My life has literally been shaped by things you can quantify (diagnoses, brain pathways, hunger hormones, tethered cords) and things you can't (grief, survival, denial, the strange ways family forms and breaks and reforms). For some reason (well..I know the reasons but I don't have time to trauma dump…), I've always felt pressured to pick one side—to either be logical or emotional, scientific or imaginative, clear or chaotic. But writing *The Hum* and talking about it with you and the class really showed me that writing, especially fiction, is sort of the one place where I don't have to split myself like that. It can be both. It *is* both.

I also want to say how much the kindness in this class mattered to me. I don't think people realize how much small things—*tone, gentleness, how someone phrases feedback*—can affect whether a student feels safe enough to create. The timing of this semester was really, really brutal for me, and there were many days I walked into class carrying more than anyone could see. But I really never felt judged in class and you never ever made me feel like I was failing for being overwhelmed, and I can't express my gratitude. You really taught the class in a way that made every person feel considered, and that's not something I take lightly. It made the work feel possible even on days when I didn't (and still don't) feel like myself.

The workshop feedback also really helped me to understand my own writing instincts better than I expected. I learned that often, I tend to rely on the atmosphere of a story when I'm

afraid of being specific with the plot. I learned that I can mistake vagueness for emotional depth. I learned that characters can't just orbit a narrator—they need their own lives, contradictions, history…just some more overall dimension. I learned that scenes need pressure and change, not just mood. And lastly, I think I learned (or am learning) what it means to build toward a real emotional hinge rather than just circling around it constantly.

Revising *The Hum* as my last activity in this class is I think the moment where all of that really clicked. I could see where I had held back, where the story was hiding behind metaphor, and where the emotions never landed because I never actually allowed the characters to clash in real ways. I think reworking it forced me to be a lot clearer, braver, more honest—and made me confront the parts I avoided because maybe they just felt a little too close to the truth. And now, looking at the difference between the first draft and the revised version, I think I'm starting to understand that my writing doesn't fall apart when I let myself feel things—it gets sharper.

Ultimately, this class has just really helped me to understand that fiction isn't about escaping life—it's about shaping it into something readable, something survivable, and something that lets you breathe differently after you've finished writing it.

Thank you for holding a space where I could figure that out, for being so patient with me during these last few months, and for reading our drafts with so much care and for giving us feedback in a way that actually made me want to revise instead of hide. And lastly, just *thank you* for reminding me that writing doesn't have to be perfect in order to still be alive.

Sincerely,

Kate Fletcher

Writing Exercise #5

The Pendulum

By Kate Fletcher

The swing wasn't much to look at—just a piece of wood tied to two ropes, fraying where they scraped against the stone ceiling—but it was all she had left that felt like ritual. So she took it upon herself to keep getting on it—pushing forward, and pulling back—over and over again—until the creak of the rope became the closest thing she had to a clock.

From the cave's mouth the city was spread out, with towers split open like ribs, streets collapsed in on themselves, and smoke still rising even though there was nothing left to burn. The city never moved, and neither did she, not really—just the same back and forth on the swing, a pendulum too stubborn to stop.

And as she began to swing, so did her thoughts. But recently, all she could think about was *him*—the boy on the hill. She thought about him more than she wanted to if she was to be truthful with herself. She recalled the way he limped toward her as if he wasn't sure if he wanted to live or not—his face caked with dirt—his hair obviously hacked unevenly with a knife.

At first she saw what she was supposed to see: *the enemy, the other side, the reason her father died and her mother didn't make it past the first winter.* But when she really looked at him—like *really* looked and stopped telling herself the story she'd been fed since she was old enough to hold a weapon—all she saw was another kid. Probably not much older than her—or definitely not much younger.

Just someone who had run out of places to go.

She remembered the way he'd said *please*—his voice cracked and broken. That single word had clung to her longer than his blood had.

Please.

Like I had the power to fix anything. To fix the world around us. She'd told herself she didn't have a choice. I mean, that's what her father always said—that mercy is weakness—and wrath is survival. And for the longest time she'd believed him, because believing meant none of

it was for nothing. *Believing* meant her mother's death *wasn't* pointless, that her father's obsession with revenge was some kind of shield, not just a habit he couldn't break.

But weeks later, as she sat and swung on the swing, she couldn't make the story hold up anymore. She kept on replaying his face, doing her absolute best to twist it into something monstrous, evil—trying to convince herself he'd have killed her if she hadn't acted first.

But every time, all she could see was the same thing: someone who looked a little too much like her. A kid who had grown up with hunger gnawing at his stomach and grief gnawing at everything else. A kid who probably got told the same thing she did—that mercy would get him killed—until the moment he didn't believe it anymore. Until the moment he was forced to look at her and ask for something else instead.

And what did she do?

She didn't even allow herself to hesitate.

She lunged, because pausing would've meant thinking, and thinking might have made her choose differently. She stabbed too quickly, too cleanly, like she was afraid of the silence that would follow if she gave him time to keep talking. The image of him falling hasn't left her—and the sound hasn't either.

And the truth was—*or is*—killing him hadn't made her safer. It didn't give her more food or more strength or more certainty about the world. All it had given her the memory of his face, the echo of his voice—and the fact that she'd carried her father's curse forward to another generation.

The swing groaned as she pushed herself higher, then back again, the rope carving its groove deeper into the ceiling.

The city was still the same—broken and empty.

She realized she wasn't swinging forward at all, not really—just tracing the same arc over and over, shrinking the world down until the only movement she could manage was this pointless back and forth she had grown so used to.

Her father had been wrong. Wrath hadn't kept them alive—it had just left her lonelier. And the worst part was knowing that when another kid climbed another hill someday, they'd make the same choice, because she hadn't been strong enough to stop the cycle.

The rope creaked again, its fibers splitting a little more and more with each pass. So the girl leans back, her legs stiff, and does her best to swing as high as she could—despite swinging with a heart that is extremely heavy.

Writing Exercise #2

Manipulation Successful

By Kate Fletcher

The nurse had told us to wait, which of course—if you know anything about hospitals—meant nothing.

"Why do you think it's taking this long?" I asked.

Mom didn't answer right away. She was pretending to read one of the old magazines on the table, flipping the pages without looking.

Better Homes & Gardens, 2018.

A family was smiling on the cover with their golden retriever—smiling as though they'd never had to wait for anything harder than a dinner reservation.

"You *could* go home," she said finally.

"Get some sleep, catch up on your homework—which I know you're probably avoiding right now by being here."

"Yeah," I said. "Because I'm really known for that."

She shut the magazine and looked at me, her face pale under the fluorescent light. Her hair had flattened in the back from leaning against the wall.

“I didn’t ask you to come.”

“You didn’t have to,” I said with one of my classic over exaggerated eye rolls. “It’s not like you leave voicemails when things get bad. You just assume people will materialize right in front of you like the Genie does when Aladdin rubs that lamp.”

Her mouth twitched—but turned into a smirk. “And look! Here you are!”

I leaned back in the plastic chair and sighed heavily.

The legs wobbled, uneven on the beige tiles. “Congratulations. Manipulation mission successful, mom!”

That got a short laugh out of her, but it didn’t last. She rubbed her temples with both hands, like she was trying to scrub out everything I’d said.

Across the waiting room, a vending machine hummed like a cheap refrigerator. Someone had left a Coke inside—purchased, forgotten, trapped behind glass. I stared at it for too long.

“You don’t have to be cruel,” she said finally.

“I’m not being cruel. I’m just aware of what’s happening here and being honest.”

“You think I don’t know what this takes out of you?” Her voice cracking on the word *you*. She lowered it quick. “You think I don’t see it?”

The hum of the vending machine filled the space we didn’t.

I shrugged. “I don’t know. I guess you’re just really good at pretending not to.”

She blinked hard, like she was trying her hardest to not let it sting. “That’s not fair.”

“Neither is this,” I said. I nodded toward the hallway, the closed door we were all orbiting. “None of this is fair…but we still sit here and smile for doctors and pretend we’re not drowning.”

Her eyes flicked up to mine—now sharp, wet, and angry. “What else are we supposed to do?”

And there it was: the question that nobody ever answered.

The question none of us could *seem* to answer.

What else do you do but keep sitting, waiting, letting the hours bleed together until someone—a doctor, nurse—*anyone* calls your name?

I leaned forward now, elbows on knees, voice low. “Maybe I just want you to stop acting like it’s normal.”

She shook her head slowly, like I’d said the most naïve thing in the whole entire universe. “You think falling apart would fix it? That if I start screaming, somebody’s going to come out here and hand me a miracle?”

I didn’t answer. I just looked at the Coke behind the glass, sweating patiently, waiting for whoever had paid for it to claim it.

When she spoke again, her voice was smaller. “If I stop pretending, I *won’t* get back up—don’t you understand that??”

I thought about it.

The way she sat at hospital bedsides like a professional mourner, the way she carried silence around as if it were oxygen.

And *maybe*…it was.

“Yeah,” I said, looking at my feet solemnly. “I understand.”

We sat there a long time, listening to the machine hum, waiting for the other to break the silence first.

Original Workshop Draft

The Hum

Word Count: 3125

By Kate Fletcher

By late afternoon, the air had the texture of wet wool, the kind that sticks to your skin and asks if you're still breathing.

I'd opened the kitchen window an inch to let it breathe, but the air that came through felt like *soup* someone forgot to season. The hum had been faint all day—just enough to notice if you were already listening for it.

Mr. Dalton was out front again, pacing slow circles in the gravel with his clipboard. He never looked down while he walked, he'd just let the pencil trace figures like he was keeping score for some kind of game that only he understood the rules of. Sometimes I thought he was counting people, other times minutes—maybe both, depending on what the day had taken.

Either way, the pages kept piling up.

I leaned on the counter with a glass of water and watched him through the blinds. Nora's car was still in the same spot, crooked like always, a front tire half on the curb. She hadn't left the complex in days. I hadn't either, but at least I told myself *I might.*

When the power cut off around five, it didn't feel dramatic. No pop, no spark. The lights just dimmed until the world felt a few shades thinner. The refrigerator sighed. And then silence—the kind that *knows* it's being listened to.

I didn't move for a while, just let my eyes adjust, watching the last of daylight bleed across the counter until it turned everything the color of rust. Somewhere outside, someone called a name, and for a split second, I thought it was *mine.*

Then came the hum again—lower, steadier.

It started under the floor this time, crawling up through the soles of my feet until it met my ribs. It wasn't loud—just *present*—like the house had decided to breathe on its own.

I grabbed my phone out of habit. Dead. *Of course*.

When I set it back down, it made a hollow little thud on the counter that sounded like an *exclamation mark*.

By the time I stepped onto the porch, the air had changed. Not colder—just heavier. It pressed against my shoulders in a way that made me aware of how *human* I was. Across the lot, Mr. Dalton was still pacing, but a little slower now. After every few steps, he'd stop and tilt his head like a man trying to hear the answer to a question he hadn't asked yet.

"You feel that?" he called, voice steady but off by half a beat.

"Yeah," I said, and he nodded like that was all he needed.

The sky had that strange twilight tint, not quite blue, not quite orange — like the colors had forgotten how to blend. A kid's bike lay on its side by the fence, back wheel spinning without anyone touching it, the chain ticking softly, steady as a clock that didn't know who it belonged to.

When Nora appeared at the bottom of the stairs, her face was flushed, hair sticking to her forehead. “It’s…it’s happening again,” she said, voice low, urgent. “I heard it by the laundry room. Like…like the ground was trying to r*emember* something.”

I had opened my mouth in protest—but she was already walking toward the back of the complex—and just waved me on as if she’d suspected I was already following her.

The hum thickened as we crossed the lot, deep enough to rattle the soles of our shoes. Each step felt slightly out of sync with gravity, like we were walking uphill even on flat ground. When we reached the gap by the fence, the smell of the marsh hit—metallic and sweet—*like rainwater left in a tin can*—the kind of smell that promises thunder but never keeps it.

And, today—the ditch was fuller than usual.

The culvert’s mouth glinted faintly, and the reflection on the water didn’t match the sky. Above it, the light shimmered—subtle at first, then sharper—like a mirage bending air around heat that wasn’t there.

Nora stopped just before the railing, her hand hovering above it. “It looks…*off*,” she said. “Do you see it?” She asked hesitantly.

“Yeah.” I wasn’t sure I did, but *lying felt easier than explaining* the feeling crawling up my spine.

“It’s like it’s…*repeating* itself,” she said.

“What?”

“The light. *Watch*.”

And she was right.

The reflection rippled twice when there should've been one. It was only a fraction of a second, but it was enough to make my stomach dip.

From behind us, the gravel crunched. Mr. Dalton was coming down the path with his flashlight, breath already uneven. "You two shouldn't be out here," he said, but it didn't actually sound like a real warning. Instead, it sounded a bit more like *hope* just masquerading as an authority figure.

The hum deepened again. But this time, it wasn't in the air anymore—it was in *us*.

My fingertips buzzed. The railing trembled. I could feel my heartbeat trying to keep pace and failing.

Mr. Dalton stopped beside us, one hand braced on the post, the other on his chest. "Feels different tonight," he murmured.

"Different *how*?" I asked.

He shook his head. "Like..like I don't know…it's *learning* or something like that."

None of us spoke for a while after that. The ditch gurgled, the sky held its breath, and the air around us pulsed in slow, impossible rhythm.

When the first flash came—*barely visible, and more color than light*—I didn't flinch. I just watched the far bank split, two edges of the same world sliding out of sync and then snapping back together again.

Nora gasped softly. “Oh my god,” she whispered.

But Mr. Dalton just stared, his eyes reflecting that thin, flickering shimmer. “It’s just heat,” he said, voice shaking a little. “Just…*heat*.”

Except it wasn’t.

The air had stopped moving. Even the frogs had gone quiet. And for the first time in weeks, I wasn’t sure which version of silence I was standing in.

The light kept trembling across the water long after we stopped talking. It wasn't a storm light—as—there wasn’t any thunder that came with it. It was smaller than that, like something seemingly testing itself.

The frogs had gone quiet, the mosquitoes had forgotten their job, and the ditch made a sound I’d never heard before—*a slow, looping gulp*—as if the water had grown a throat and was considering using it for the first time.

Dalton adjusted his flashlight and the beam skittered across the bank, too bright for a second, then useless. He muttered something under his breath about interference, though the batteries were fresh and I knew he was trying to sound scientific for his own sake.

The reflection still hadn’t settled—each ripple lagged a half second behind the *real* water—as if time itself was buffering.

Nora leaned forward, whispering, “It’s…*listening*.”

I didn’t answer. I was too busy trying to convince myself I hadn’t thought the same thing.

Nora knelt at the edge, resting her hand on the railing, her knuckles white against the wood. "*You*—you feel it—*right*?" she whispered.

"Yeah," I said. "It's *everywhere*."

She glanced over her shoulder. "It's like some kind of…pressure…but inside out?"

Dalton half laughed, that thin, brittle laugh people use when they're really just doing their best to disguise a tremor. "Pressure is *directional*," he said with certainty, and mostly to himself. "It can't just be…*inside out.*"

"Maybe *that's* the problem," I murmured.

He turned to me, his lamp haloing dust and gnats in the air. "You think this is a problem?"

"I think it's a *question*," I corrected.

He stared for a long moment, then looked away. "You were always pretty damn bad at following instructions."

"Well..I wasn't the one writing them down for everyone else to suffer through."

He didn't answer—and just turned back and looked toward the water.

The surface moved oddly, like two ripples running in opposite directions and canceling each other halfway. I'd never seen water hold *still* while simultaneously *moving*. The sight of it made me want to step back *and* closer at the same time.

From behind us, a door slammed somewhere in the complex—loud, then completely swallowed. The air rippled with the sound and then flattened again. I realized I could see the other buildings through the shimmer now, their edges doubling for a second before catching up with themselves—like the world couldn't decide which version to keep.

Nora reached into her pocket and pulled out her phone. "I'm gonna try and film it…"

Dalton and I both let out a loud '*NO'* at the same time. She froze, I guess a little startled at how quickly it came out of the both of us.

"Why *not*?" she said, frowning like a little kid. "Maybe it'll show…whatever *this* is?"

"It won't," I said flatly. "You'll just lose the battery."

Dalton nodded, eyes still on the ditch. "And maybe…something else."

Nora pocketed the phone again without arguing. She was trembling, though she'd never admit it. I wanted to tell her to go back, to stay inside, but the words stayed stuck somewhere between my ribs and my teeth.

The air shifted again.

A breeze—*or what should've been a breeze*—swept across the lot, but it didn't touch us. The trees moved, the water stirred, and yet nothing changed temperature. I could feel the *ghost* of motion around me, but yet, not the presence of motion itself.

Dalton crouched, squinting into the culvert. His lamp caught the metal ring, and for an instant the inside seemed lit from somewhere deeper than his light could reach. "It's reflecting

wrong," he said. "There's physically and scientifically *no* angle that makes sense for something like this."

Nora and I exchanged a worried glance.

I didn't want to see what he saw, but I couldn't not look either. The reflection wasn't of us—it was of the ditch, inverted, but lagging behind like a second thought. The delay was barely perceptible, but once you saw it, you couldn't unsee it.

A long moment passed where no one spoke. It was as if the hum were waiting for us to decide something.

"I think we should go," Nora said finally, her voice thin and frail, almost a little apologetic.

Dalton straightened. "If this is measurable, *it's worth*—"

"It's not measurable," I interrupted. "It's something more personal…"

He turned to me, annoyed. "Everything's measurable."

"Then measure *this*," I said, gesturing at the air between us. "Tell me how *heavy* it feels."

He opened his mouth, then shut it. The hum rose a fraction—barely enough to call it real sound—and all three of us fell silent again.

I could taste metal in the back of my throat. The smell of the marsh thickened—salt and iron and ozone, the air before lightning but without lightning's mercy.

Nora took a step back. "I don't like it here."

I didn't either, but oddly enough what I was feeling wasn't fear—it was *recognition.*

Dalton then shone his light one last time into the water, as if daring it to prove him wrong. The beam flickered—not from the lamp but from the air—and when the light steadied, the reflection didn't.

For a moment, the culvert's mouth stretched wider in the water than it was in the world.

"Do you see that?" he whispered.

Nora nodded, barely. "It's like it's…*breathing*."

The sound came next—not a roar, not even a voice, but a shift. Like the auditory version of turning a page too quickly. It was followed by a silence that wasn't empty but full—like everything else around us had stepped back to make room.

I felt dizzy.

The hum seemed to sync with my pulse—one beat off, then back on—then perfectly aligned. It was like my body had forgotten which rhythm was mine.

"I need to sit," I said, still processing, still feeling it.

We moved back toward the grass, but the hum stayed under us, running through the soles of my feet like low voltage. Nora crouched beside me, tucking her knees into her chest. Dalton stayed standing, light pointed at the ground like he just couldn't *bear* to turn it off.

"Maybe…it's over?" he questioned out loud after a little while.

I almost laughed. "You've said that, *like*, every day for the last month, Mr. Dalton."

“This feels…*different*,” he said quietly—almost as if he was really just admitting it to himself and didn’t care if we chose to listen in or not. “Like…like it’s waiting for us to make a choice.”

“*Us*?” Nora asked, trembling more now than she was five minutes ago.

He didn’t answer, just scribbled something onto the paper clipped to his board. I caught a glimpse of the page—our names, the date, a line drawn through Thomas’s.

“You shouldn’t do that,” I said.

“Someone has to,” he muttered. “Someone has to keep track of where the world stops.”

I wanted to tell him that wasn’t his job, that counting the holes in reality *doesn’t* actually make fewer of them. But he looked so small standing there, so convinced of the math, that I just couldn’t bring myself to.

The frogs started up again, faint at first, like the sound was coming from underwater. The hum dimmed with them, fading but never gone. The air loosened its grip, but I could still feel the pulse of it *somewhere* in the dirt.

Nora leaned her head against her knees. “Maybe we should just go inside.”

“*Maybe*,” I said, though I didn’t move. The thought of going back into my cell—or house, sorry—somehow felt wrong right now.

Dalton’s flashlight blinked once, then died completely. The dark pressed close again, the ditch glinting faintly under the last stretch of twilight.

For a second, I thought I saw someone across the water—a figure, *still and waiting*—but when I blinked, it was gone.

Just…*gone*.

Nora must've seen my face. "What?" she asked.

"Nothing," I said, far too quickly for it to have sounded believable.

Dalton sighed, clicking the lamp back on. "You two need to rest," he said.

"Yeah," I said, standing. "*Probably*."

We walked back together in silence.

The gravel crunched beneath our shoes in slow, uneven rhythm, like an echo that hadn't decided who to follow.

Inside, the apartment felt smaller than it had an hour ago.

The air was too still, the rooms too aware. I shut the blinds and stood there in the dark for a while, watching the faint outline of the candle jar on the counter. The label caught the last glint of light from the street and flashed at me like a wink.

I turned it away from the window.

For a long time, I just listened—to the fan stalling, the refrigerator pretending, the hum that never completely left.

And under all of it, faint but clear as a held breath, there was another sound.

It wasn't the hum this time.

It was footsteps in the hall.

I froze, cup still in my hand. The sound came again—slow, and deliberate. One step, then another—*heel to toe*—the rhythm of someone who'd definitely lived here long enough to know where the boards creaked.

The air in the hallway had gone still. I could see the faint outline of the doorframe, the thin strip of light that leaked in from the lot outside, trembling just enough to remind me the power hadn't decided what side it was on.

"*Thomas*?"

The word came out barely above a whisper. Almost like I didn't mean to actually say it—which maybe I didn't. Kind of the same way in which you'd call to a dream right before it wakes you up.

But to my dismay—there was no answer.

I did, *however*, hear the next step come a little closer.

I set the glass down carefully on the counter, the way you do when you don't want to spook a frightened animal. But, then—the sound stopped. And for a couple heartbeats, everything stopped—the refrigerator hum, the fan's lazy spin, even the muffled chorus of frogs outside.

Then something shifted. Not a noise this time—a *feeling*. Like the air pressure in the room had taken one long breath and was just waiting to see if I'd match it.

I moved toward the door.

The handle was cool beneath my palm. For a second I just stood there, letting my pulse catch up, watching that thin crack of light stretch across the floor. When I finally opened it, the hallway beyond was empty.

But the light was wrong. *Again*.

The bulbs in the ceiling fixtures flickered in a rhythm that didn't match anything mechanical—slow, stuttering, then steady. I could smell rain though the night outside was clear.

A floorboard creaked behind me. I turned, quick, but no one was there.

The hum started again, low, just above hearing—more like vibration than sound. It felt familiar now, almost like recognition.

I went back inside and shut the door.

For a while, I just stood there, both hands flat on the counter, waiting for my heartbeat to slow. The hum didn't stop. It threaded through the cabinets, the glass, the pipes. I could feel it in the soles of my feet.

Then a soft knock came from the other side of the wall—three taps, evenly spaced.

I flinched hard enough to drop the spoon still in my hand. It hit the floor with a sound that felt too loud for the size of the room.

Another knock came, and with the same exact rhythm.

I pressed my ear to the drywall but heard nothing except the faint static of silence.

And then, faintly, a voice emerged from the airwaves.

"*Hey*—"

It was almost casual, the way you'd greet someone at a door you weren't sure would open.

I stepped back as if the wall in front of me had just grown teeth.

My mouth went dry.

"*Thomas?*?" I asked again, more urgently this time.

But this time, the word didn't feel like calling out. It felt like being called to.

Before I could move closer, the knock came one more time—it was soft, almost kind. Then the hum rose, filling the room, folding over itself until it was hard to tell if I was actually hearing it—or remembering it.

The power blinked out once again.

So, I stood in the dark, my reflection faint in the window, lit only by the last sliver of the candle I hadn't realized was still burning on the counter. Its flame was bent sideways, though there had been no draft.

Outside, somewhere down the hall, a door opened just slightly. I heard the squeak of the hinge, the slow push of air, then silence.

When the lights flickered back to life—everything looked the same.

But the glass on the counter was *gone*.

Revision Review/Log

Revisiting my story, *The Hum*, really helped me to understand both my writing habits and the parts of the story I held back in the first draft. When I originally wrote it, I was drafting through a lot of emotional noise, and I think that made me rely more on atmosphere than clarity. Workshop feedback, along with your comments, made it clear where the story needed more structure and where I needed to stop hiding behind vagueness. This revision focused on strengthening the world, the relationships, and the emotional hinge of the piece. One of the biggest issues in the first draft was world-building. The lockdown, the marsh, and the hum were all present, but none of them were tied to a clear sense of place or pattern. I revised the opening to ground the reader in the physical layout of the complex and the reality of the "temporary containment" zone. I clarified that multiple disappearances had already happened before Thomas, which raises the stakes and prevents his disappearance from feeling random. I also sharpened the timeline: *three weeks into lockdown, evening hums, recurring outages, and the way the marsh acts like a border.* These changes helped the environment feel like part of the story instead of just mood. Another major revision was deepening the characters around the narrator. In the first draft, Nora and Dalton were present, but their roles weren't emotionally grounded. Workshop readers wanted to know who they were to Chloe and why they mattered. I gave Dalton a clearer background—a former physics teacher whose instinct is to measure and analyze the unexplainable. This added structure to scenes where something strange happens, and made his presence feel purposeful instead of decorative. I expanded on Nora even more, because she carries both grief and guilt. In revision, her relationship with Thomas, her closeness to Chloe, and her instability are clearer. Their dynamic now includes tenderness, resentment, and fear, which makes the conflict between them feel real instead of symbolic. The emotional tension of

the story changed significantly. In the original draft, Chloe's grief stayed mostly implied. I realized I was avoiding direct conflict, which made the emotional pacing feel flat. In revision, I added a confrontation between Chloe and Nora that surfaces their resentment and forces both of them to say harder things. This moment became the hinge the story needed. It also allowed the supernatural moment at the ditch to feel earned instead of random. I also removed the hallway "ghost" moment from the first draft. Workshop readers found it confusing and disconnected from the rest of the story. I replaced it by anchoring everything in one central location: the ditch. This is now the place where Thomas disappeared, where the hum concentrates, and where the climax unfolds. The ditch scene was rewritten to show what Chloe experiences physically and emotionally while also showing how Nora and Dalton react. This streamlined the story and made the supernatural moment feel consistent with the world's rules. On a sentence level, I cut several metaphors, repeated images, and overly dramatic phrasing. My drafting style leans heavy on sensory language, and some of that muddled the pacing. I kept the strongest lines but trimmed anything that made the story harder to follow. I also varied sentence structure, clarified dialogue, and took out filler phrases that made the emotions feel less grounded. The final change was the ending. Professor Quaraishi suggested making the disappearance moment more symbolic rather than literally supernatural. So, instead of the entire mug vanishing, I revised it so only the hot chocolate disappears—something tied directly to Thomas. This keeps the ending mysterious without breaking the logic of the story and keeps the emotional focus on Chloe rather than the phenomenon itself. Overall, revising just really helped me to make the story clearer, more emotionally honest, and more grounded in character.

Revised Workshop Story

The Hum

By Kate Fletcher

Word Count: 2900

By late afternoon, the air had the texture of wet wool—the kind that clings to your arms and neck and makes you aware of every single inch of yourself. The complex had started feeling like that all the time: heavy, a little soured, the kind of heaviness that doesn't crush you so much as settle over you with a slow, patient persistence. Maybe it was the marsh behind the buildings or the lockdown or the way the city kept insisting this was all temporary when nothing about it felt temporary anymore.

Past the marsh, life supposedly went on. Buses ran if you could get to them. Stores were still open if you lived outside this blockade zone. People posted photos of brunch and concerts like none of this was happening. But here, between the last bus stop and the checkpoint, the world had become an in-between place. A waiting room with no receptionist, no magazines, no updates.

"Temporary containment," the officials kept calling it.

Temporary had stretched into week three.

Around dusk was when the hum usually began. It wasn't loud and it didn't rattle windows or set off alarms like one might think. It was more like someone had pressed a tuning fork against the ribs of the building and just let it ring out into the air.

You didn't really hear it. You just *felt* it.

And no matter how many times it happened, it still made you stop and pause—and not exactly in fear, but in recognition. Almost like the moment before a storm, when the pressure shifts, the birds go quiet, and you can taste the rain before it actually falls.

I cracked the kitchen window an inch. The air that seeped in felt like oversalted steam—thick, unhelpful, the kind of air that made you want to sit down until the world passed by. The hum had stayed faint all morning, pulsing softly under everything, as if gathering and trying to hold itself.

On the kitchen counter, Thomas's owl mug sat upside down in the dish rack.

It was stupid how much that mug still winded me.

Chipped on the beak, uneven glaze, a little lopsided in the way handmade things are, but he absolutely loved it. He drank hot chocolate year round—*hot chocolate in July, hot chocolate after long days, hot chocolate after fixing something for a neighbor.* He always claimed he didn't have a ritual, but he stirred clockwise three times and counterclockwise once, every single time. I don't think I actually realized that until he wasn't around to do it anymore.

The night he disappeared, he washed the mug and left it drying upside down like he'd be back in twenty minutes and *I hadn't moved it since.*

Through the blinds, I saw Dalton pacing his usual slow circles in the parking lot. He used to teach physics at the high school. You could still see it in the way he held himself, like every step was half a calculation.

Since the first hum, he'd been tracking everything: *flickering lights, the times of day when the air felt wrong, items going missing*. People whispered that he was losing it, but I didn't think he was. If anything, he was just one of the few people who hadn't given in yet to pretending that any of this was normal.

Things had started disappearing a week before Thomas.

A mailbox.

A laundry cart.

Two bikes chained to the rack by Building C.

Stupid little things you could explain away if you tried hard enough.

But then—*Thomas*.

I peered out the cracked window and saw that Nora's little blue car was still sitting crooked in its usual spot by the stairs. She hadn't left in days. Neither had I, but she somehow looked worse than I did—like sleep was an idea she hadn't been able to grab hold of.

She'd moved into the complex just a couple months before everything locked down. She and Thomas had fallen into that quick, quiet kind of closeness that looked almost impossible unless you'd seen the way he softened around her. She was also the one who found his toolbox on the stairs that night. The drawer was open, but the screwdriver was gone. He'd only gone upstairs to fix Mrs. Alvarez's oxygen tank—*five minutes*—he'd said. Nora had hugged him on the landing, then gone down to move her car.

But when she came back, he wasn't there. He was just gone.

He hadn’t walked away; he had just ceased to exist in the place he was standing.

When the power dipped around five tonight, I didn’t react.

It was happening more frequently now—the lights dimming from bright to soft to nothing like they were apologizing for it. The refrigerator gave its usual dying sigh, and the room thinned, losing half its sound.

Someone outside called a name. Every name sounded a little like his now.

The hum rose through the floor, settling under my ribs like a hand I hadn’t asked for. My phone was dead. They were always the first things to go when the humming began.

I set it down, and the thud felt too sharp in the quiet. The owl mug stared at me with that stupid chipped beak, and I looked away.

Before I heard her footsteps, I felt Nora outside the door. Grief has an aura to it; it changes the air around a person.

When I opened it, she stood at the foot of my stairs, arms wrapped tight around herself like she was trying to keep every piece of herself from spilling out. Her hoodie was inside-out. Her hair stuck to her temples. If this had been any other week, I would’ve asked her if she was sleeping. Now it just felt like a stupid question.

“It’s starting again,” she said.

Her voice wasn't shaking—but it carried a tiredness so deep it felt borrowed from some older, larger grief.

She jerked her chin toward the back of the buildings.

"It's strongest near the ditch tonight."

I felt the shift in my stomach the way you feel a coming storm behind your teeth.

I stepped outside. Locked the door out of habit. The gravel cracked under our shoes as we walked toward the back of the complex. With each step, the hum thickened—not louder, just closer, gathering itself.

Blinds were closed. No doors cracked open. Most of the time, fear doesn't look like screaming; it just looks like people closing things quietly. Nora moved fast, like something was pulling her ahead. Her grief seemed to work that way—very forward, urgent, and restless. Mine just sort of sat heavy in my chest, making me feel anchored and unsteady at the same time.

"We should tell Dalton," she said.

"We don't have to," I answered, nodding ahead.

Dalton had already stopped pacing. He was standing still at the edge of the lot, flashlight lowered, staring toward the back as if he'd been waiting for us.

"It's shifting," he said when we reached him. "Toward the ditch again."

"What does that mean?" Nora asked, already bracing.

Dalton exhaled. "It means the hum's consolidating."

He didn’t need to say anything else.

Consolidating meant patterns.

And patterns meant danger.

We moved together down the narrow path between Building C and the sagging fence where the mailbox had disappeared last week. The hum pressed at the air, making it feel thick enough to chew. Even the bugs avoided this strip now, diverting sharply the way animals do in documentaries right before the narrator says “*And then they sensed the danger*…”.

Nora slowed as the ditch came into view; her arms folded around herself like a reflex. She stared at the water, her face hardening and softening in turns.

“It’s stronger than yesterday,” she whispered.

Dalton didn’t touch the railing—something he used to lean on without thinking.

“It’s accelerating,” he said. “And…not evenly.”

This was where Thomas had last been seen. Or not seen. Which honestly felt more accurate.

Walking closer felt like moving into the breath of something ancient and patient.

The ditch itself looked unchanged—brown water circling lazily, reflections shivering in slow patterns. Nothing overtly alarming, if you didn’t know better.

But the air around it had a different density, *like a threshold.*

I stood closer than either of them, not brave, just tired of being afraid from far away. Up close, the spiraling water made me feel *like something deep beneath the surface was watching us watch it.*

Nora's voice broke the quiet first.

"I hate this place."

Dalton nodded, but didn't take his eyes off the water.

"Me too."

"You don't hate it the way I do," she said.

He finally looked at her, confused. "Nora—"

"Don't," she snapped, the word sharper than her usual temper.

He stopped.

And that's where everything really began to unravel.

Dalton tried to recover first, clearing his throat as if that could reset the air. "Okay," he said, slipping into his old cadence, "we know the hum is strongest around points of disappearance, but that doesn't mean this exact location is—"

"—*responsible*?" Nora cut in, arms tightening across her chest. "Another one of your theories?"

"It's not a theory," he insisted. "It's data."

“It’s guesswork,” she said. “Dressed up like something helpful.”

“Nora,” I warned, but she didn’t even glance at me.

Dalton’s jaw tightened. “I’m trying to make sense of this so we don’t lose anyone else.”

“You say that,” she said, stepping toward him, “but you talk like if Thomas had just understood the ‘data,’ none of this would’ve happened. Like he made a mistake.”

Dalton flinched. “I never said that.”

“You implied it,” she said. “Every time you take notes like there’s a right answer he missed.”

The hum rose half a breath under our feet, subtle but unmistakable.

“Nora,” I said again, more firmly.

She turned toward me then, her eyes bright and hurt and exhausted. “And you,” she said. “You act like I don’t get to talk about him.”

My stomach dropped. “That’s not true.”

“You think I don’t notice?” she said. “Every time I bring him up, you shut down. You walk away. You look at me like I’m trespassing.”

“You’re not,” I said, but my voice came out thin.

“You make me feel like my grief is some kind of inconvenience,” she pressed. “Like I’m borrowing something that belongs to you.”

“That’s not—”

“You think I didn’t love him.”

I opened my mouth. *Closed it.*

“Of course you did.”

“Then why do you act like I’m not allowed to miss him?”

The hum pulsed once, tightening the air in my ears.

“Because you didn’t know him the way I did,” I said, the words slipping out before I could temper them.

Nora stared. “What is that supposed to mean?”

“It means he raised me,” I said, louder than I intended. “*He was my first best friend*. *My first real parent*. The one who stayed when everyone else didn’t. You had him for weeks. I had him for decades.”

“That doesn’t mean my grief isn’t real,” she said, voice cracking.

“I didn’t say it wasn’t real. I said it wasn’t the same.”

“Why do you get to decide that?”

“I’m not deciding anything,” I said, though I wasn’t sure that was true. “I’m just telling you I can’t keep pretending your grief equals mine.”

She reeled back like I’d swung at her.

“You think I’m selfish,” she said quietly.

I didn’t answer.

I didn’t have to.

Her breath hitched. “You know what? If it weren’t for you,” she said, voice trembling, “*he wouldn’t have even been here*.”

It landed like a crack of lightning.

Dalton inhaled sharply. “*Nora*—”

She froze as soon as she said it.

Her face broke.

“*Chlo*—no—I didn’t mean—”

“Yes you did,” I said, barely above a whisper. “*You meant exactly that*.”

Her eyes filled. “I didn’t. I swear.”

“*Don’t touch me*,” I warned when she took a small step forward.

She stopped immediately.

And then—

the hum surged.

Not violently—just *decisively*. Like someone turning their head toward a sound.

The air thickened around my legs in a slow, syrupy pressure. My breath stuttered. The world blurred at the edges like a smudged mirror trying to refocus.

Dalton moved closer in a single sharp step. “Chloe,” he said, calm but alarmed, “do not move.”

My arms prickled. “*I’m not*.”

“Just—stay where you are,” he said.

But something in the air didn’t feel interested in what I wanted.

My vision dipped, just a fraction, like the world lagged behind itself. The ditch rippled in a pattern too synchronized to be natural. The reflection in the water blinked a beat slower than I did.

“*I don’t feel right*,” I said quietly.

Nora’s voice broke in terror. “Chloe? Chloe—look at me.”

“I am,” I said, except my gaze kept drifting past her shoulder, like it belonged to someone a half second behind me.

The hum sharpened into a higher frequency I felt in my gums.

Dalton’s eyes widened. “Her outline—look—Nora—she’s shifting.”

“I’m what?” I whispered.

My right foot slid half an inch forward. I hadn’t meant to move at all.

“Oh my God,” Nora cried. “No. No, no—Chlo—stop—please—stop—”

“I’m trying,” I said, but trying didn’t matter. My body wasn’t syncing with the moment I was in. It felt like I was standing on the seam between two versions of the same second.

Dalton reached for me, hands steady despite his terror. “I’ve got you. Don’t panic. Just stay with us.”

Nora grabbed my other arm, her face streaked with tears. “Chloe, I’m sorry,” she begged. “I didn’t mean what I said. Please don’t—please—he couldn’t bear it if—”

Her voice dissolved.

I wasn’t being pulled.

I wasn’t being taken.

It felt more like I was slipping out of the shape of myself.

The ditch spiraled in time with the hum, turning the water into a slow, intention filled sort of wheel.

“Chloe,” Dalton said, voice strained, “look at me. Right here. Stay in this moment.”

“I’m…I’m trying,” I breathed, though I wasn’t entirely sure where my breath was landing.

Nora tightened her grip. “Stay with us. *You’re here. You’re here.*”

And then—

as quickly as the hum had surged—

it cut out.

Everything snapped sharply back into place.

My feet were on the ground.

My breath was mine again.

The water returned to its sluggish, uninteresting circle.

The silence afterward buzzed almost louder than the hum.

Dalton exhaled shakily and loosened his grip. “We’re going back. Now.”

Nora swiped at her eyes with her sleeve, still holding onto my arm until she was certain I wouldn’t fold.

We walked back to the complex in a silence so thick it felt like another presence walking with us. Every window we passed was dark. Every door sealed. The whole place was practicing a kind of collective stillness that made my skin itch.

When we reached the stairs, Dalton hesitated. “You two go up,” he said. “I need to write down everything while it’s fresh.”

“You shouldn’t be alone,” Nora said.

He forced a small, humorless exhale. “I already am.”

I didn’t have the energy to argue.

Nora followed me up. Our footsteps echoed too loudly in the stairwell, each step measuring out the remains of adrenaline. The hallway felt much narrower than before. I paused at my door because, for a flicker of a second, something about it seemed off—an angle that wasn't wrong, just…*slightly* different.

When I blinked, it was normal again.

"Do you see that?" I asked.

Nora squinted. "See what?"

"Nothing," I said, although it didn't feel like nothing.

Inside, the apartment felt heavier but not threatening. More like someone had been in it while we were gone, moving carefully, making sure to put everything back exactly where it belonged. The air carried a faint warmth that didn't match the outage.

Nora lingered near the door. "Do you want me to stay?"

I didn't trust my voice not to crack, so I just nodded.

The kitchen looked the same as we'd left it, except the owl mug—it sat a fraction of an inch off its drying spot. Not enough to blame on anything. But enough for me to notice.

I picked it up with both hands.

"I'm going to make cocoa," I said quietly, almost a little embarrassed. "Just… for *him*."

Nora nodded with a soft, wounded sincerity. "He'd like that."

I filled the kettle. The kitchen lights flickered back to their dim emergency glow. The cocoa tin felt heavier than it should, carrying its own tiny universe of memories: Thomas stirring quietly after long days, leaning against the counter while steam fogged his glasses, handing me cups without asking whether I wanted one.

The kettle clicked off.

I poured the water into the mug. The cocoa bloomed and darkened. The smell filled the room—warm, soft, and unbearably familiar.

When I set the mug on the counter, steam rose in a thin ribbon.

Nora sat quietly across from me. Neither of us spoke. The hum wasn't present, and yet something in the air still felt tuned, like a string pulled tight.

I stepped toward the window to shut it fully—it had drifted open more than I thought—and as I slid it closed, I heard a small, low vibration beneath my feet.

Not the hum. *Just its ghost.*

I turned back to the counter and noticed that the mug was still there.

But the cocoa was gone.

Not spilled.

Not evaporated.

Just…gone.